

very helpful if you don't know where your phone is. Go to IFTTT on a web browser or the smartphone app, and login. In either case, you need to install the IFTTT app on your smartphone, and login to that as well. If you do not have an account, you can instantly create one using a Facebook or Google account. Search for Alexa and you should see a number of applets. If you are iffy about security, look for the applets officially published by IFTTT. Now, Select **Hey Alexa, call my device**. Here, you can specify the phrase you want to use for Alexa to trigger the call. This uses two services on IFTTT, Amazon Alexa as well

as VoIP Calls. Click on Save. You will be redirected to your Amazon account where you will have to confirm the integration. Once that is done, IFTTT will send a confirmation to your smartphone. You are all done now. Just say "Alexa, call my device", and your phone should start ringing. The home screen of the IFTTT app has all the connected services, and you can remove any services that you don't want or are no longer using. Tap on the services, tap on the gear icon, and tap on remove to do so. IFTTT applets can be used to get around all kinds of limitations of Alexa, such as syncing Alexa to-do lists with your device, or adding events to the calendar.

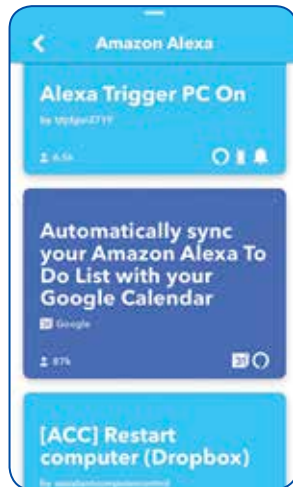
MAKE YOUR OWN IFTTT APPLET

This is a simple applet that we made where you can use a custom phrase to note down the current time in a Google Sheets document. The date and time are added sequentially. Such a setup can be used to track the start and finish timings of gaming sessions, workouts, or just about anything else. Fire up the IFTTT app, and tap on the + icon next to **Make your own Applets from Scratch**. Now go to **This > Say a specific phrase**. Enter a phrase, we are going to go with **start game**. Then tap on **Create trigger**, and then tap

on **That**. Search for and select **Google Sheets** and then **Add row to spreadsheet**. Select the Spreadsheet name. If a spreadsheet of the same name does not exist, a new one will get created. Now note that the formatted row has

a **TriggeredAt** element followed by **|||**. The **TriggeredAt** is an ingredient that notes down the current time, and the **|||** provides a cell separation. For the purpose of this workshop, we will be adding **Start DnD session** next to the **|||**. Now tap on **Create Action**. A preview of your applet will appear, but you are not done yet. Depending on the screen size of your phone, you may need to scroll down to tap on **Finish**. Now, repeat

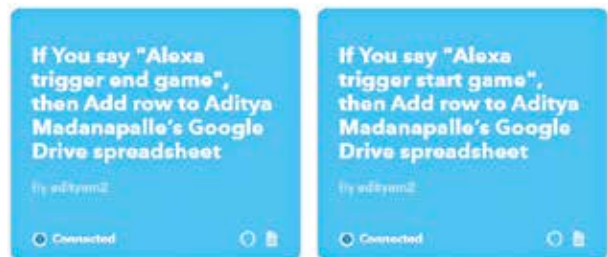
the process with another trigger phrase, **end game**, and add **End DnD session** after the **|||**. Now tap on **Create Action > Finish**. The applet is all set, and you can vocally track the timings of DnD sessions in Google Sheets with a custom voice command to Alexa. A similar approach can be used to create other IFTTT applets. Note that Alexa offers a rather limited set of "ingredients", which are variables that can be specified at the time of triggering an action. Google Home supports many more. You can also chain IFTTT triggers, for example, adding a new row to a Google Sheets document can be the if this for another then that. Now let us do something a little more complicated. For the **If** trigger, select **Amazon Alexa** and **New song played**. Then, go to **That** and select **Spotify** then tap on **Add track to a playlist**. In the Artist name field, add **ArtistName** as an ingredient. Then tap on **Create action**, and then **Finish**. Now, every time a track is played on Alexa, through any streaming service, that track is added to a playlist on Spotify.



Some IFTTT Applets

CHANGE AN ALEXA RESPONSE WITH BLUEPRINTS

We are now going to use **blueprints**. **amazon.in** to replace particular questions with custom answers. You can set the trigger phrase, as well as the response, and this supersedes all other programming, routines, and skills that Alexa may have. Note that **blueprints.amazon.com** will allow you to make the skills just as well, but you will frustratingly be unable to use them as long as you are in India. To use custom skills made through blueprints in India, you have to go to the **.in** address. Essentially, when fiddling around with Alexa, you need to be hyper aware of the domain that you are working on, and the region settings for Alexa. Click on **Custom Q&A**, from the **Featured Blueprints** section. Click on **Make your Own**. Now, just type out the text in the **When you say: Alexa**, field, as well as the **Alexa will say:** field. We went with a long-ish response to "What are the house rules for Uno?" as an example.



Custom IFTTT Applets

CREATE A SKILL WITH BLUEPRINTS

There are a number of Blueprints available that will let you customise the experience. The Quiz Blueprint lets you create a question and answer game for up to four friends. Alexa can check for the right answer, and deliver a related fact just afterwards. The Facts skill lets you relay a random fact from a list on any topic, and you can keep adding to the Facts. One Blueprint we found incredibly useful is known as Houseguest. Here, you can add custom items to a list to help someone find their way around the house. One category is known as "Where is the..." Here you can add items such as sandpaper, facewash, helmet and so on, write down the location, and provide

